

ROASTED EGGPLANT WITH OLIVES AND SUN-DRIED TOMATO VINAIGRETTE

SERVES
4-6

TOTAL TIME
1 h

INGREDIENTS

907 g	Japanese eggplants, quartered lengthwise and widthwise
9 g	Salt
112 g	Olive oil, for cooking the eggplant
55 g	Red wine vinegar, for cooking the eggplant
38 g	Olive oil, for the vinaigrette base
15 g	Garlic, finely chopped
48 g	Tomato paste
100 g	Sun-dried tomatoes, dry-packed
149 g	Taggiasca olives, pitted
25 g	Anchovies, finely chopped
74 g	Salt-packed capers, rinsed and finely chopped
1	Orange, a quarter of the peel finely chopped with the pith removed and the fruit reserved
1/2 tsp	Calabrian chile oil, for the vinaigrette base
55 g	Red wine vinegar, to finish
84 g	Olive oil, to finish
7 g	Calabrian chile oil, to finish
2 sprigs	Basil, stems removed

METHOD

1. Arrange the eggplant quarters on a sheet pan, skin side down. Salt them and leave them 10 to 15 minutes, then blot away the moisture that beads on the cut faces with paper towel.
2. Set a large sauté pan over medium heat with half the olive oil. Lay half the eggplant in flesh side down and cook 6 to 8 minutes, turning the pieces so they color evenly, until golden brown and tender. Eggplant drinks oil, so add more whenever the pan starts to look dry.
3. Turn the pieces skin side down and cook 1 to 2 minutes more, by which point the flesh should be soft to the center.
4. Pour half the red wine vinegar into the pan and cook 1 to 2 minutes, until it has evaporated. Lift the eggplant out and set it aside, then run the same sequence again with the second batch, the rest of the oil and the rest of the vinegar.
5. For the vinaigrette base, warm the olive oil and garlic in a small saucepan over low heat for 10 to 15 seconds, to the point it turns aromatic without taking color. Stir the tomato paste in and cook it 3 to 5 minutes, until the red deepens and it binds with the oil and garlic. Take the pan off the heat to cool.
6. Cover the sun-dried tomatoes with warm water in a small bowl and leave them 3 to 5 minutes, only until they have just softened.
7. Pulse the olives in a food processor to a very fine chop, stopping short of a puree, and tip them into a mixing bowl.
8. Drain the tomatoes, put them in the processor with the cooled tomato paste mixture and pulse to a uniform paste.
9. Fold that paste into the olives together with the anchovies, capers, chopped orange peel and the chile oil. Set 120 g aside. The rest goes into an airtight container under a layer of olive oil and keeps up to 2 weeks.
10. Juice the orange. Add the juice to the reserved 120 g of base along with the remaining red wine vinegar, the 84 g of olive oil and the chile oil, then stir it together.
11. Transfer the eggplant to a large bowl. Spoon the vinaigrette over and turn it gently, so the pieces hold their shape.
12. Move it to a serving platter and scatter the basil leaves over the top.

NOTES

Salting the cut eggplant for 10 to 15 minutes pulls water out of it. Wipe that off before the pieces go into the pan. Eggplant absorbs a great deal of oil, so keep more within reach and top the pan up whenever it dries. The olives want a very fine chop rather than a puree, which is what keeps texture in the finished vinaigrette. The base makes far more than this dish needs. It is good spread on crostini or used as a pasta sauce, and it keeps two weeks under oil.